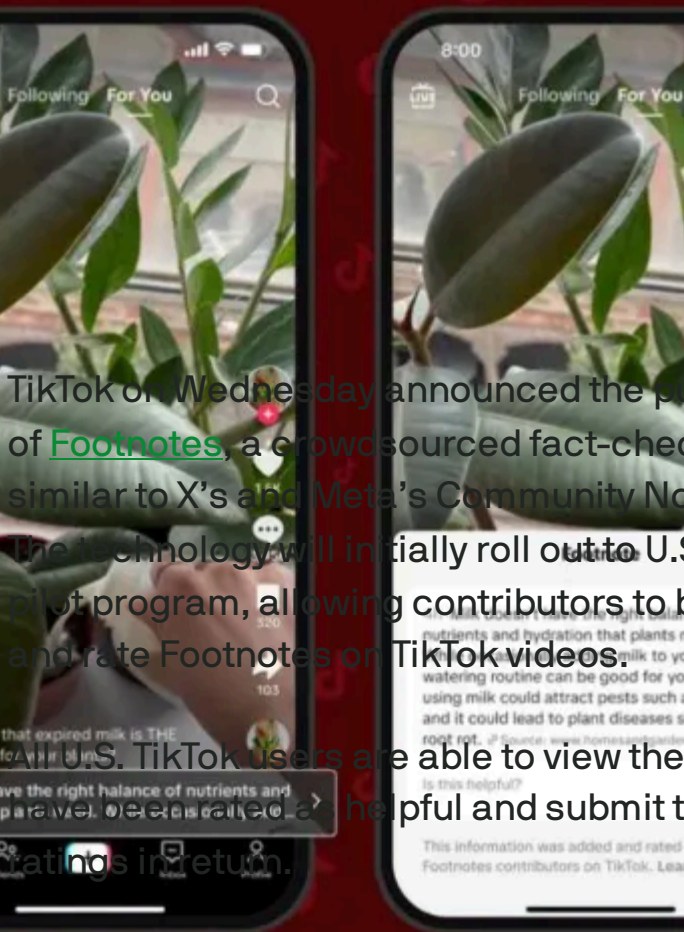


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Footnotes, TikTok's
crowdsourced fact-
checks, launches in the
US



TikTok on Wednesday announced the public launch of **Footnotes**, a crowdsourced fact-checking system similar to X's and Meta's Community Notes feature. The technology will initially roll out to U.S. users as a pilot program, allowing contributors to both write and rate Footnotes on TikTok videos.

U.S. TikTok users are able to view the notes that are helpful and submit their own ratings in return.

The company first **announced its plans to test Footnotes** in April. At the time, it described the feature as a way to give the community more context around TikTok's content.

Like X's Community Notes and other similar programs, TikTok uses a bridging algorithm that tries to find consensus among people who typically have different views. If both sides rate a note as helpful, then it's more likely to be true, according to this method. This also guards against brigading, where one side tries to sway a decision their way by voting similarly.

The company says notes can help people better understand what they're seeing on the platform by adding more information and context. Sometimes the person who posted the video that gets a note is actively trying to misrepresent a situation, while other times they may have simply missed other information or updates that could be helpful for viewers.

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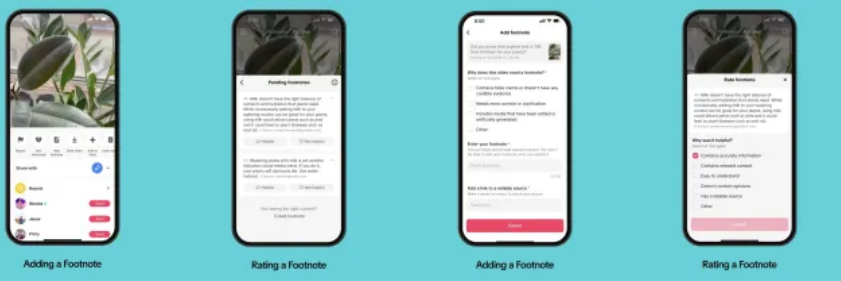


IMAGE CREDITS:TIKTOK

TikTok began allowing U.S. users to [apply](#) to be a contributor back in April, as long as they were at least 18, had been on TikTok for more than six months, and had no recent history of violating TikTok’s Community Standards. Since then, TikTok says nearly 80,000 U.S. users have qualified as Footnotes contributors.

Though new to TikTok, Community Notes-style features have existed for several years.

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Twitter pioneered this idea, originally called Birdwatch, [back in 2020](#). It officially [rolled out the Birdwatch fact-checks the following year](#) and [expanded the program globally in 2022](#). Now called

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Community Notes, the feature has expanded under Elon Musk’s ownership of Twitter/X. More recently, those efforts include allowing [AI to generate notes](#) and new ways to use the system for [highlighting popular content](#) on the platform.

X’s [open source](#) Community Notes concept has also inspired similar systems at other social media companies — particularly those looking to appease conservatives who felt that traditional fact-checking systems were biased against them.

In an effort to make amends with the Trump administration and hoping to thwart increased regulation, [Meta dropped fact-checking](#) this year in favor of its [own Community Notes system in the U.S.](#), raising concerns about the [spread of misinformation](#). YouTube is also experimenting with its take on this type of system with its feature called [Notes, which launched last year](#).

However, TikTok says its Footnotes initiative will expand upon its existing Global Fact-checking Program, not replace it.

The company says it continues to work with more than 20 [IFCN](#)-accredited fact-checking organizations, in over 60 languages and in 130 markets around the world.

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TikTok begins testing Footnotes, a new Community Notes-like feature

Aisha Malik — 8:08 AM PDT · April 16, 2025

TikTok is testing a new “Footnotes” feature that works similarly to Community Notes on X. The social network announced on Wednesday that Footnotes will allow users to add additional context and relevant information to videos to help others better understand certain content, starting in the United States.

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The company says Footnotes will complement its current suite of measures designed to help people understand the reliability of content, such as content labels and its fact-checking program. In other words, TikTok isn't replacing fact-checking with Footnotes, unlike Meta, which is doing exactly that through its [new Community Notes feature](#).

Similar to other community notes systems on [X](#) and [Facebook](#), Footnotes uses a bridge-based ranking system designed to find agreement between people who usually have different opinions, the company says in a [blog post](#).

The system works by allowing users who have differing opinions to leave, and vote on the helpfulness of, a footnote. Footnotes will only become visible to the community once they're rated as "helpful." At this point, the broader TikTok community can vote on their helpfulness as well. TikTok says the system will become more effective as more footnotes get written and rated on different topics.

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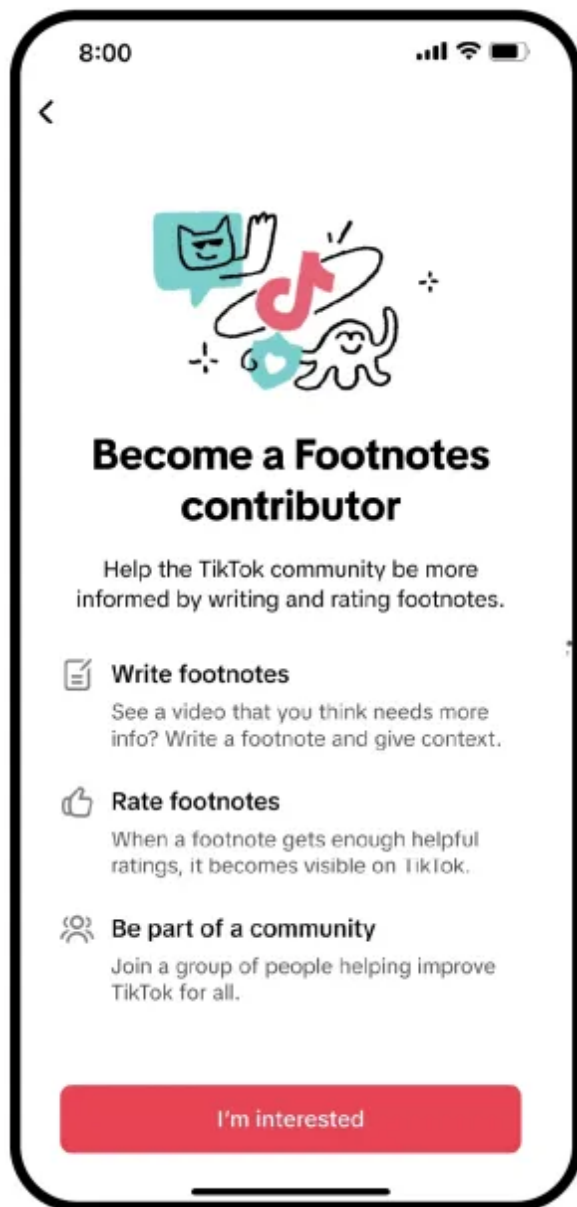


IMAGE CREDITS:TIKTOK

While TikTok's comments section and other tools like Stitch and Duet allow users to share dialogue around a video, the new Footnotes feature gives users a new way to share their expertise and add a layer of context using a consensus-driven approach to enhance credibility. TikTok points out that Footnotes could be particularly useful in instances where videos cover complex STEM topics, include potentially misleading statistics, or share updates on ongoing events.

The launch of the new feature comes as TikTok has been called out for [spreading misinformation](#) about [important topics like health and elections](#). TikTok likely hopes that the introduction of Footnotes will help curb the spread of some of this misinformation

by enlisting its user base to add credibility and additional context to videos.

Starting today, United States users can [apply](#) to be a Footnotes contributor if they are at least 18 years old, have been on the platform for more than six months, and have no recent history of violating TikTok’s community guidelines.



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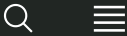
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TikTok plans to begin surfacing Footnotes from contributors over the coming months. At the moment, it’s unknown what exactly Footnotes will look like, and where on a video they will appear.

TikTok says it continues “to partner with more than 20 IFCN-accredited fact-checking organizations to assess the accuracy of content on TikTok in over 60 languages and 130 markets around the world. Footnotes adds to these efforts with more ways to add helpful details that may be missing, ultimately enriching discussions on TikTok and improving the experience for viewers, contributors, and creators alike.”

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Hoping to stall a ban, TikTok says it generated \$14.7B for US small businesses last year

Sarah Perez — 9:58 AM PDT · April 4, 2024

As U.S. lawmakers weigh a possible TikTok ban, the ByteDance-owned short-form video app released [an economic impact report](#) on Thursday. In it, the company touts the platform generated \$14.7 billion for small- to mid-size businesses (SMBs) last year, and a further \$24.2 billion in total economic activity, supported through small business's use of TikTok.

In addition, it says that over 7 million U.S. businesses rely on TikTok and that 224,000 jobs were supported by small business activity on the platform in 2023. Of those, 98,000 jobs were supported directly within SMBs on TikTok. The states with the largest impacts included California, Texas, Florida, New York and Illinois.

The study was performed by the economics forecasting group, Oxford Economics. It measured SMB activity on TikTok, along with ad spend and ROI, and leveraged census data and other measurements to come to its conclusions.

While a report of this size and scope couldn't be thrown together overnight, the timing of its release is likely not coincidental.

In March, [a bill that could ban TikTok](#) passed in the House of Representatives. President Biden said [he would sign it into law](#) if it also passes in the Senate. Of concern to TikTok, is that the bill gained bipartisan support, passing the House with a 362-65 vote, despite former President Trump's change of position on the matter. The Trump administration had previously sought to ban TikTok, calling it a national security risk, but [Trump now opposes a ban](#), saying that Meta would benefit.

Meta is clearly preparing for a possible future where TikTok could be banned, if not spun out from ByteDance. On Wednesday, Facebook was updated to support [a new video player across its social network](#); it will recommend Reels, long-form and

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The Browser Company launches a \$20 monthly subscription for its AI-powered browser

Ivan Mehta - 22 minutes ago

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Google takes on ChatGPT's Study Mode with new 'Guided Learning' tool in Gemini

Aisha Malik - 13 hours ago

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Instagram takes on Snapchat with new 'Instagram Map'

Aisha Malik - 17 hours ago

Live videos, but default to showing them in vertical format, as on TikTok.

YouTube and other short-form video platforms could also gain increased exposure if TikTok were to be banned, and could pave the way for startups competing in the space, as well.



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TikTok's economic report is a clear attempt to make a case for why the app should be allowed to continue to operate, noting that \$5.3 billion in tax revenue last year was supported by small business activity on TikTok, including as a marketing and advertising platform.

The company also presented a variety of case studies where business owners claim that TikTok helped to drive sales, website traffic, and other forms of additional revenue.

Tying the ban to the app's economic impact is a solid PR strategy — especially since a group of TikTok creators got a judge to [successfully block](#)

[Trump's TikTok ban in 2020](#) by saying it would affect their professional opportunities, like brand sponsorships, and ability to make an income.

Though TikTok has been urging users via in-app messages to [call Congress to protest a ban](#), the bill still faces a more difficult [path to pass in the Senate](#) — and more so now that the Republican party's leader has reversed his position on the ban.

[The controversial bill that could ban TikTok faces a rocky road in the Senate](#)

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33% of US TikTok users say they regularly get their news on the app, up from 22% in 2020

Sarah Perez — 1:17 PM PDT · September 20, 2022

Earlier this summer, a Google exec admitted that [TikTok was eating into its core Search business](#), particularly among younger users. But that's not all TikTok is now being used for, [a new Pew Research Center study](#) indicates. According to the findings from a report that examined Americans' use of social media for news consumption, 33% of TikTok users now say they regularly get their news on the social video app, up from just 22% in 2020.

Meanwhile, nearly every other social media site saw declines across that same metric — including, in particular, Facebook, where now only 44% of its users report regularly getting their news there, down from 54% just two years ago.

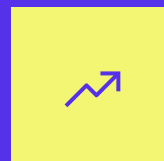
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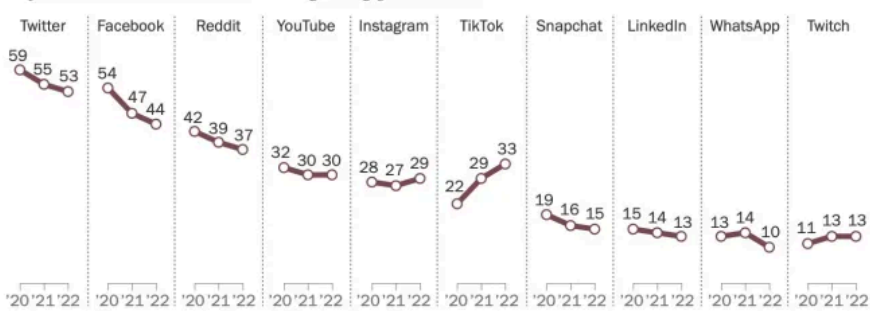
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Social media sites by portion of users who regularly get news there

% of each social media site's users who **regularly** get news there



Note: Nextdoor was first asked about this year so there is no trend data.

Source: Survey of U.S. adults conducted July 18-31, 2022.

PEW RESEARCH CENTER

IMAGE CREDITS: PEW RESEARCH

This data suggests TikTok has grown from being just an entertainment platform for lip syncs, dances, and comedy to one that many of its users turn to in order to learn about what's happening in their world.

That may raise concerns, given TikTok's connections to China — a topic it was recently pressed to clarify [in a Senate hearing focused on national security](#). The hearing had followed the release of a [BuzzFeed News report](#) that had discovered how China-based ByteDance employees had been regularly accessing TikTok's U.S. users' private data.

If TikTok were to become one of the primary ways younger people in the U.S. learned about news and current events, then the app could potentially provide a channel for a foreign power to influence those users' beliefs with subtle tweaks to its algorithm.

[Meta, TikTok, YouTube and Twitter dodge questions on social media and national security](#)

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For the time being, however, TikTok is not a primary source of news consumption across social media — that honor still resides with Facebook.

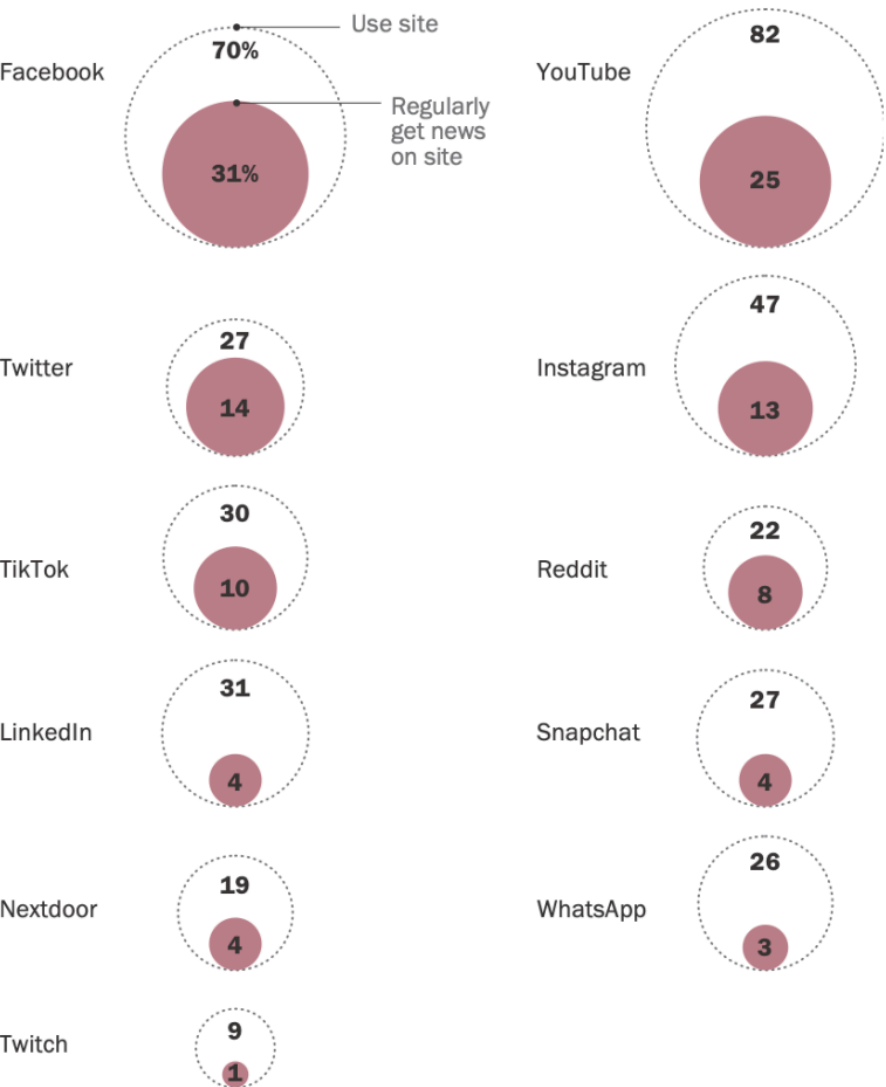
Pew found that 31% of U.S. adults report regularly getting their news from Facebook, which is higher than the 25% who get their news from YouTube, the 14% who get it from Twitter, or the 13% who get it from Instagram.

TikTok was in fifth place by this ranking, as only 10% of U.S. adults said they regularly get their news on the video app. (Of course, when TikTok's sizable user base of those under the age of 18 grows up, these metrics could quickly change.)

LinkedIn (4%), Snapchat (4%), Nextdoor (4%), WhatsApp (3%) and Twitch (1%) were much smaller sources of news among Americans, the study also found.

News consumption and use by social media site

% of U.S. adults who ...



Source: Survey of U.S. adults conducted July 18-Aug. 21, 2022.

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IMAGE CREDITS: PEW RESEARCH

In addition, Pew somewhat backed up Google’s assertion that it was losing traction to TikTok and other social media apps,[as it noted that](#) the percentage of U.S. adults who often got their news via web search had dropped from 23% in 2020 to 18% in 2022.

But it didn’t necessarily point to TikTok or any other social platform as gaining, as the percentage of adults often using social media of any sort for news consumption dropped from 23% to 17% between 2020 and 2022, as did other forms of news consumption like news websites and apps.

IMAGE CREDITS: PEW RESEARCH

It's not clear that any single platform is benefiting from these declines, as Pew didn't uncover a shift from digital news sources to others, such as TV, print or radio — all those saw declines in news consumption as well.

IMAGE CREDITS: PEW RESEARCH

Still, digital devices continue to outpace TV, Pew said, as the latter has seen its usage of it often drop as a source for news consumption from 40% in 2020 to 31% in 2022.

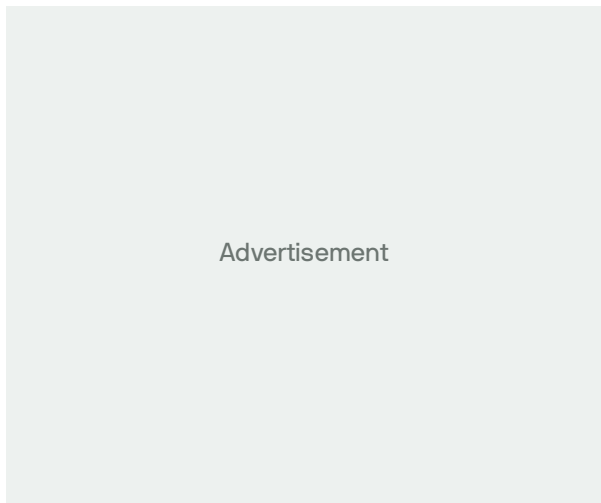
Plus, when asked about preferences, more Americans (53%) said they would rather get their news digitally than on TV (33%), radio (7%), or print (5%) — an answer that's stayed consistent since 2020.

[Google exec suggests Instagram and TikTok are eating into Google's core products, Search and](#)

Updated, 9/23/22 to add when the usage described was “often” for getting news via web, social and through digital devices, for further clarity as it relates to Pew’s questions about regular usage.

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